I am , Because of you - A Facilitator’s Journey to Rewriting Her Own Life

“They don’t know how schools look like, and they feel education is not for us … if they work for 9 hours and get paid 200 rs, they feel it is enough, because they don't know how to calculate, and some feel im not meant to use a computer or so on. This is the myth we are breaking here for the children"

These words had the weight of a huge responsibility. Monica, a 28 year old facilitator working at Makkala Jagriti is working at Government Child Care Institution at Bangalore. She facilitates life skills, basic numeracy and computer skills to children who have been left out of formal education. Her work involves more than facilitating. It demands a great deal of patience, perseverance and empathy to connect children with stories much heavier than their age.

Child Care Institutions (CCIs) are a vital part of India’s Juvenile Justice system, offering shelter, care, and rehabilitation to children in need of protection or those in conflict with the law. Makkala Jagriti’s CCI Program strives to create safe, nurturing, and empowering environments in government-run CCIs and Observation Homes, ensuring that children who have faced adversity receive opportunities for holistic growth . By nurturing their social, emotional, physical, intellectual, and creative development, the program helps children rebuild confidence, develop essential life skills, and prepare for reintegration into society.

Monica’s journey in CCI did not begin with her job in Makkala Jagriti. It traces back to her childhood. Growing up in a large family with 6 siblings in J.P Nagar in Banglore, life took a turn for Monica and her siblings at the age of 11 when her father passed away. Along with her siblings she was sent to a private CCI because her mother couldn’t afford to look after for their education and basic needs.

“I was lacking with the care and affections and everything. And the people who come from outsiders who used to sponsor us kind of food or clothes, or something else, made me feel bad…

If my parents are in the good status or are here and how are these children lucky enough to be having their parents. It is kind of a different feeling. When the result is announced in school, every parent used to come with their children but for us sisters used to come and it’s kind of difficult in the CCI home.”

Living in those emotionally tormenting circumstances, she managed to complete her education with the help of non profit organisations that helped children transition out of Child Care Institutions.She completed her education in BBA and left CCI home once she turned 18.

Monica secured her first job during the COVID 19 pandemic, being someone who easily bonds with people made it easier for her to enjoy her work in the social sector. Over time and experience she wanted more growth in her career and she took steps to secure that.

Her entry at the Government Child Care Institution Bangalore was far from smooth. The work came with its own peculiar demands. The work required her to be extremely patient, navigate difficult emotional realms of the children and unpredictability that everyday brought in.

“ When I started, I was fine, a week in, I wanted to quit” Monica admits

“I didn’t know how to handle a child. They don’t know basic behavior and everything, and literally I felt heavy- heavy and heavy work”

What changed this dilemma for Monica was a conversation she had with a colleague who noticed the growing stress and disappointment in her. The conversation shook her out of her current concerns and made her realise the goal is to provide holistic education to children and the way to do that is to not force it on them. To let them blend into it in their own sweet time. This is also the conversation that made her understand more about the CCIs.

It was serendipitous. To realise that this is her story too. This is where she was and this is what makes her the best fit to help these children there.

I also faced the same thing, I compared myself with the children that day. And there is no one to talk with me and who cares about me. The same- same problem that the children are facing. Then I started to understand what CCI home is, how the children are, then I started to talk to them. After listening, after hearing their problem, I understood that I have to go after them so they won’t come after me.“

She was able to create a beautiful bond with the children hereafter. To some she is a friend, to some she is motherly, to some she is their favourite maam, with whom they can share anything and everything. Monica approaches the unpredictableness of the daily sessions with a smart plan. She says she always goes to class with a Plan A and Plan B and if the children are too hesitant to do something one day, there is always a plan B. Always something to get them to learn something new every day.

The work is so special to Monica because she feels she helps them out of their own beliefs of not being good enough to having a dignified life.

“I feel proud to work with the children in CCI because they need my help more than anyone else. They don't know a single thing. Now by the time they are released, they’ll learn something. When they say, ma’am, because of you I learned. I know this. That is my achievement.”

For Monica these are more than achievements. In a way she is rewriting her own story here. A beautiful poetic Justice!

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